

A COLLECTION OF HISTORIES, BUILDINGS & MASTERWORKS

GREAT GALLERIES OF THE WORLD

Twenty museums. Twenty stories.
Featuring original paintings by Gabriela



Foreword

This book began as a simple wish: to bring together, in one place, the museums that have shaped the way we see art, and to let Gabriela's own paintings stand for a moment beside the masterworks that first moved her.

Twenty museums, twenty stories: some born from an emperor's whim, some from a widow's devotion, some from nothing more than a handful of people who believed their city deserved better. Each survived fire, war, theft, or simple neglect to become what it is today, a place where a stranger can stand in front of a five-hundred-year-old painting and feel, for a moment, less like a stranger.

Gabriela has spent a lifetime doing exactly that, first as a student in the High Museum's art school, later under a teacher in Cali who taught her that painting is not a technique but a way of paying attention. Her chapter in these pages is not an afterthought. It is the reason the rest of the book exists.

Twenty-six years into this life together, I still find I learn the most about looking at art by watching her look at it.

— *Donald*

GREAT GALLERIES OF THE WORLD

A Collection of Histories, Buildings & Masterworks

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01 Musée du Louvre

Paris, France

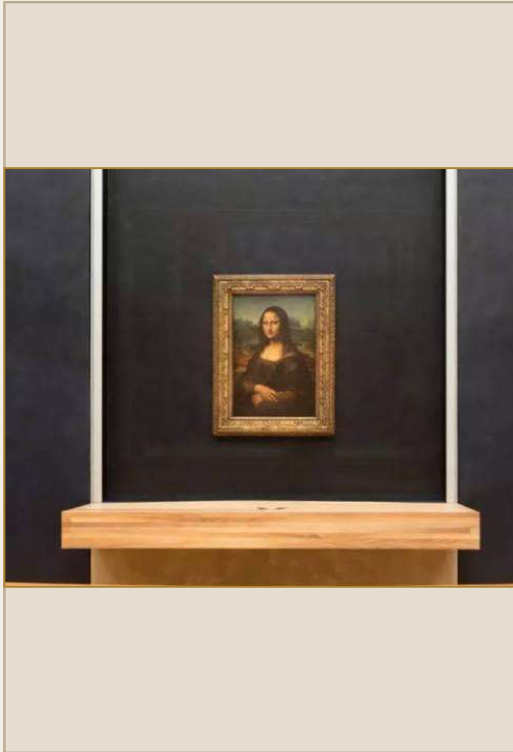
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Fortress, 1190 · Museum opened 1793

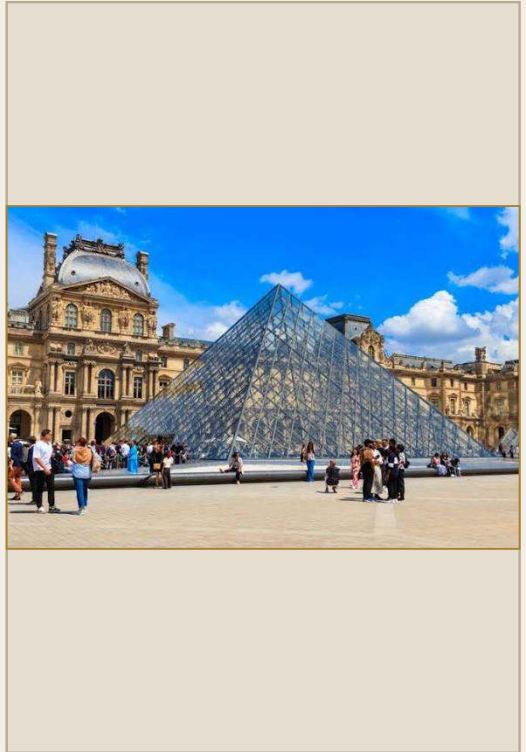
ARCHITECT(S)

Pierre Lescot · I. M. Pei (Pyramid, 1989)

What began in 1190 as a fortress guarding the western edge of Paris became, six centuries later, the birthplace of the modern public museum. When the revolutionary government threw open the doors of the former royal palace in 1793, it declared that art belonged to the people, not the crown. Two hundred years on, I. M. Pei's glass pyramid — once ridiculed as an act of vandalism — has become as recognizable as the paintings it shelters, none more so than the small, smiling portrait stolen from these walls in 1911 and never forgotten since.



Mona Lisa, Musée du Louvre. Leonardo da Vinci's portrait, painted in the early sixteenth century, hangs behind protective glass in the Denon Wing.



Exterior, Musée du Louvre. I. M. Pei's glass pyramid, opened in 1989, rises in the Cour Napoléon before the former royal palace.



Interior gallery, Musée du Louvre. The Galerie d'Apollon, redecorated after a fire in 1661 under Charles Le Brun, glitters with gilded stucco and painted ceiling panels.

02 The Metropolitan Museum of Art

New York, USA

FOUNDED

1870

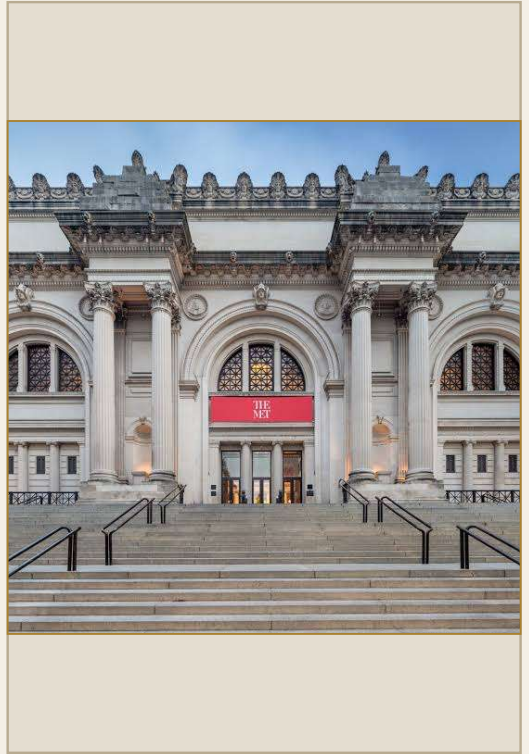
ARCHITECT(S)

Calvert Vaux & Jacob Wrey Mould · Richard Morris Hunt

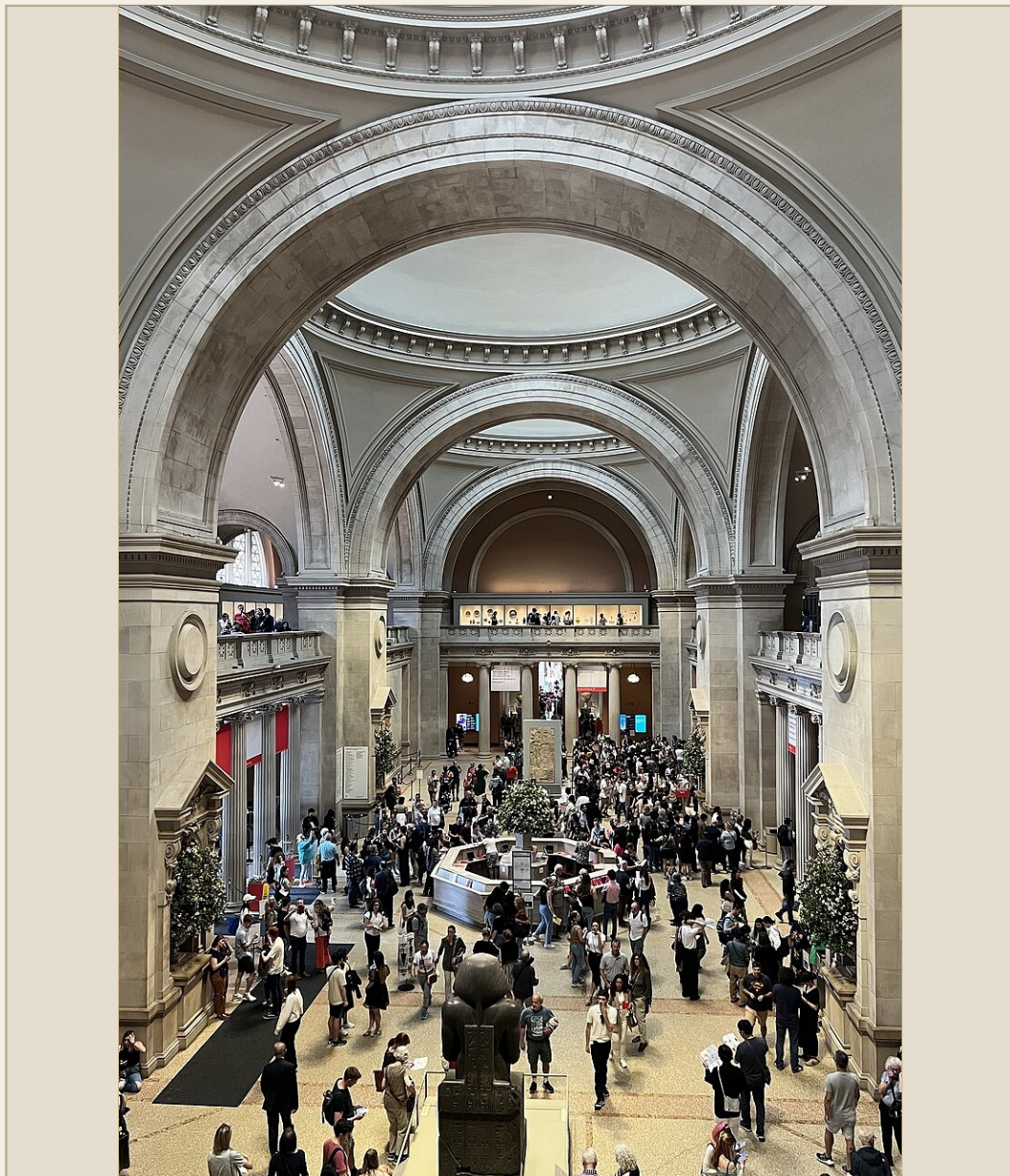
A handful of financiers, artists, and dreamers gathered at New York's Union League Club in 1870 convinced that Americans deserved a museum equal to Europe's greatest. From a single Roman sarcophagus, the Met grew into a Gothic fortress on Central Park, then a Beaux-Arts palace behind Richard Morris Hunt's soaring facade. Today its two million objects range from Egyptian temples reassembled stone by stone to the medieval Cloisters overlooking the Hudson — a collection built, quite literally, one civilization at a time.



Washington Crossing the Delaware, The Met. Emanuel Leutze's 1851 canvas, more than twelve feet high and twenty-one feet wide, hangs in the American Wing in a gilded, eagle-crowned frame.



Exterior, The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Richard Morris Hunt's Beaux-Arts façade, completed in 1902, rises above the Fifth Avenue steps.



Great Hall, The Metropolitan Museum of Art. Beneath stone arches and domes, the hall serves as the museum's central crossroads, gateway to a collection of two million objects.

03 Vatican Museums

Vatican City

FOUNDED

1506

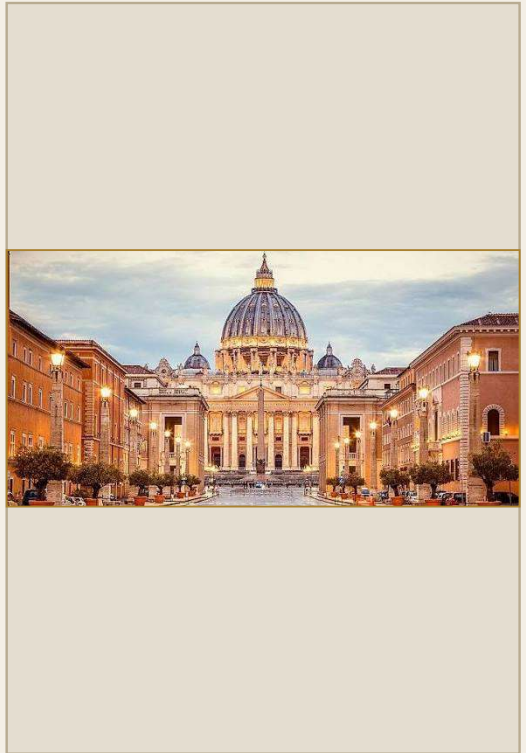
ARCHITECT(S)

Bramante · Michelangelo

The story begins in a Roman vineyard in January 1506, where workers unearthed an ancient marble so extraordinary that Pope Julius II bought it within the month and put it on display — the seed of a collection that would grow into one of the world's great museums. Julius set Michelangelo to work on a chapel ceiling modeled on the proportions of Solomon's Temple, a four-year labor that remains, five centuries later, the destination every visitor's route through the Vatican inevitably leads toward.



Sistine Chapel, Vatican Museums. Michelangelo's ceiling frescoes, painted 1508–1512, arch above the chapel, with his *Last Judgment* (1536–1541) covering the altar wall.



St. Peter's Basilica from Via della Conciliazione. The Vatican Museums lie just beyond the basilica, inside Vatican City.



Interior gallery, Vatican Museums. Marble columns, seated statues, and painted vaults line galleries built to display the papal collections of antiquities.

04 British Museum

London, UK

FOUNDED

1753

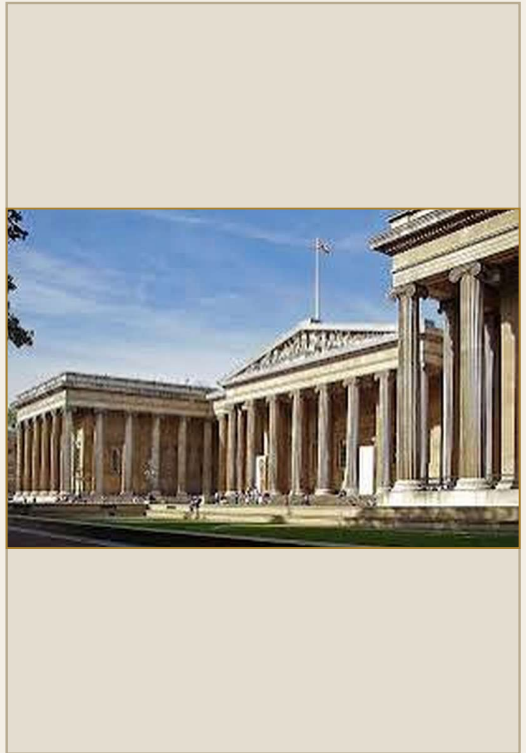
ARCHITECT(S)

Sir Robert Smirke · Norman Foster (Great Court, 2000)

The world's first national public museum began with a physician's dying wish. Sir Hans Sloane bequeathed his lifetime's collection of curiosities to the nation in 1753, and Parliament built a home worthy of it: Robert Smirke's Greek Revival colonnade, later crowned by Norman Foster's glass-roofed Great Court. Inside, the Rosetta Stone still draws the crowds it drew when Napoleon's defeated army surrendered it in 1801 — one chapter in a collection whose ownership disputes are as storied as the objects themselves.



Rosetta Stone, British Museum. Inscribed in 196 BC with one decree in hieroglyphic, Demotic and Greek, the stele unlocked the reading of ancient Egyptian.



Exterior, British Museum. Sir Robert Smirke's Greek Revival colonnade, begun in 1823, fronts Great Russell Street.



Interior gallery, British Museum. Human-headed winged lamassu from the Assyrian palace at Nimrud flank the entrance to the Assyrian galleries.

05 State Hermitage Museum

St. Petersburg, Russia

FOUNDED

1764

ARCHITECT(S)

Bartolomeo Rastrelli

Catherine the Great never intended to found a museum — she simply wanted 225 paintings a Berlin merchant had assembled for someone else. From that impulsive purchase in 1764 grew a private imperial gallery inside Rastrelli's Baroque Winter Palace, opened to the public only in 1852. Its greatest test came in 1941, when curators raced to evacuate the collection to the Urals before Leningrad's 900-day siege began — a rescue that ensured Rembrandt's masterpieces would survive a war that nearly destroyed the city around them.



The Return of the Prodigal Son, State Hermitage Museum. Rembrandt painted this canvas in the last years of his life; it is one of the Hermitage's greatest Dutch masterpieces.



Exterior, State Hermitage Museum. Rastrelli's green-and-white Baroque Winter Palace, completed in 1762, faces Palace Square.



Jordan Staircase, State Hermitage Museum. Rastrelli's ceremonial stair in the Winter Palace, restored by Vasily Stasov after the 1837 fire, rises from the main entrance.



State carriage, State Hermitage Museum. Gilded carving, painted panels and red silk curtains mark this coach as built for court ceremony.



Interior gallery, State Hermitage Museum. Crimson walls and gilded frames set off the large Baroque canvases of the Flemish galleries, where paintings hang from cornice to bench.

06 National Gallery

London, UK

FOUNDED

1824

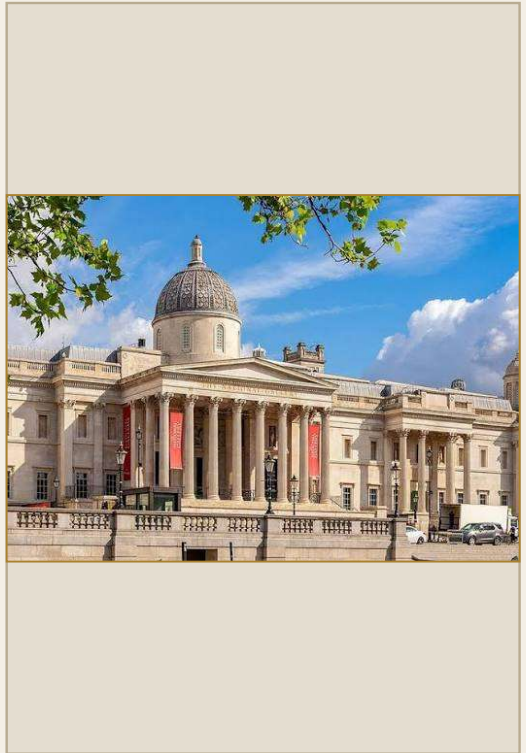
ARCHITECT(S)

William Wilkins · Venturi & Scott Brown (Sainsbury Wing, 1991)

Unlike most great museums, London's National Gallery was not born from a royal collection but built from scratch, when Parliament paid £57,000 in 1824 for 38 paintings from a banker's estate. William Wilkins's Trafalgar Square building was so derided on completion — one king called it a 'nasty little pokey hole' — that its cramped galleries eventually forced British art into a museum of its own, the Tate. Two-thirds of what hangs here today arrived not by purchase but by gift.



The Arnolfini Portrait, National Gallery. Jan van Eyck signed and dated this oil-on-oak double portrait in 1434; the gallery bought it in 1842.



Exterior, National Gallery. William Wilkins's Trafalgar Square building, completed in 1838, looks south across the square.



The Umbrellas, National Gallery. Pierre-Auguste Renoir began this canvas around 1881 and finished it about 1886; it entered the gallery in 1917 with Sir Hugh Lane's bequest.



Interior gallery, National Gallery. Gilded frames hang against grey walls beneath a coved, skylit ceiling.

07 Uffizi Gallery

Florence, Italy

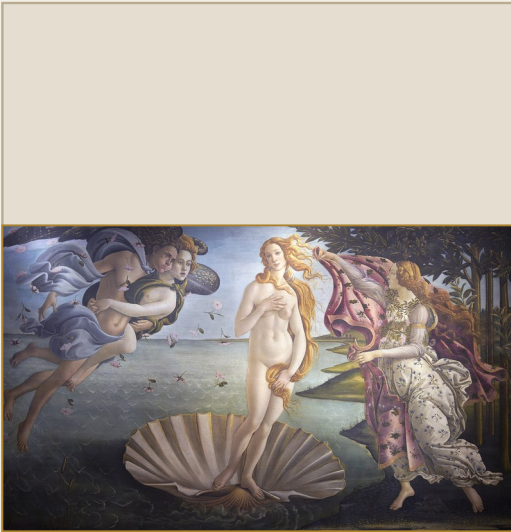
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1560 (offices) · 1769 (public gallery)

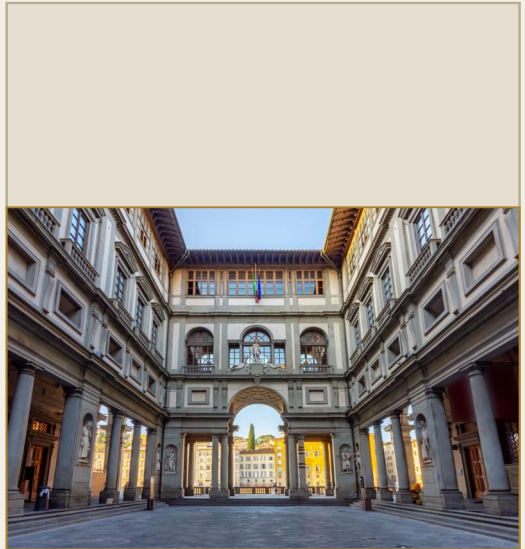
ARCHITECT(S)

Giorgio Vasari

Cosimo I de' Medici built the Uffizi to house Florence's bureaucrats, not its masterpieces — the name itself means 'offices.' It was his son who converted the top floor into a private gallery, but it was the last of the Medici, Anna Maria Luisa, whose 1743 Family Pact truly created the museum we know: she bequeathed the entire collection to Tuscany on one condition, that it never leave Florence. That promise survived Nazi occupation, a devastating 1966 flood, and a 1993 Mafia bombing — and holds to this day.



The Birth of Venus, Uffizi Gallery. Sandro Botticelli painted this tempera on canvas in the mid-1480s; it is among the most celebrated works in the collection.



Exterior, Uffizi Gallery. Giorgio Vasari's U-shaped courtyard, begun in 1560 as offices for the Medici state, opens through an arch toward the Arno.



Interior gallery, Uffizi Gallery. Framed miniatures cover the red walls of one of the Uffizi's more intimate rooms, set between green marble columns above an inlaid marble floor.

08 Museo del Prado

Madrid, Spain

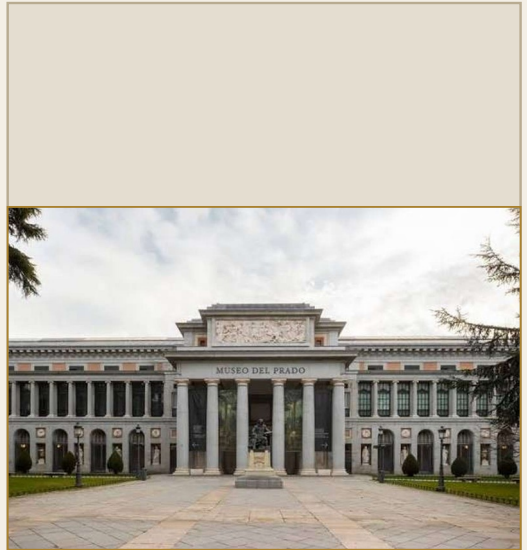
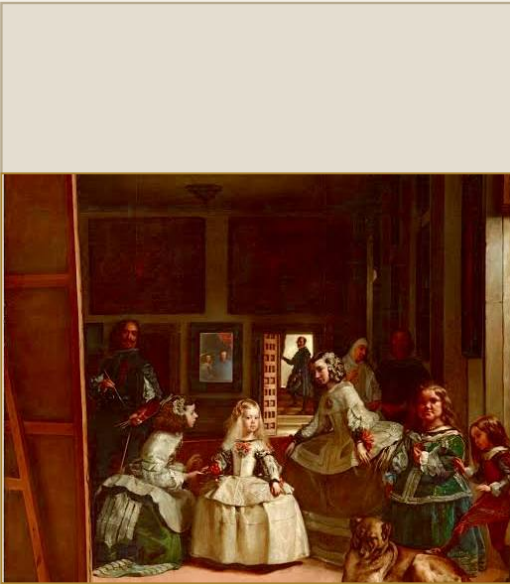
FOUNDED

1819

ARCHITECT(S)

Juan de Villanueva · Rafael Moneo (extension, 2007)

Charles III commissioned this Neoclassical building to house a natural history cabinet; it was his grandson, urged on by a queen with sharper taste, who turned it into a royal picture gallery instead, opening in 1819 with just over 300 paintings. During the Spanish Civil War, staff sandbagged the basement and then evacuated the collection abroad under international protection — a wartime odyssey that safeguarded Velázquez's court and Goya's darkest visions alike for the millions who visit today.



Exterior, Museo del Prado. Juan de Villanueva's Neoclassical building, begun in 1785 under Charles III, with the statue of Velázquez before its north entrance.



Interior gallery, Museo del Prado. A portrait of Queen María Isabel de Braganza, who urged the museum's creation, stands behind a wooden model of Villanueva's building.

09 Rijksmuseum

Amsterdam, Netherlands

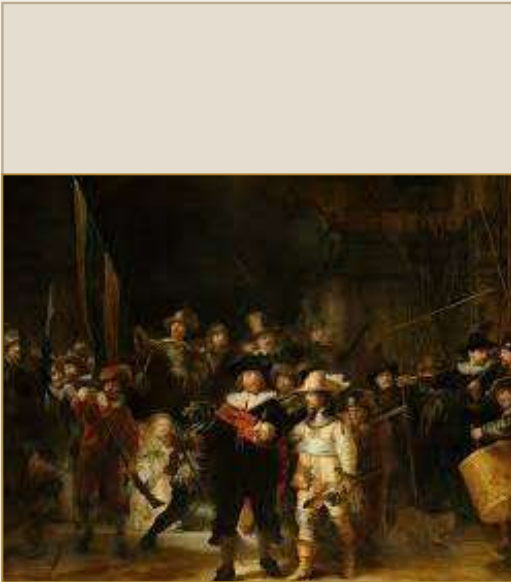
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1798

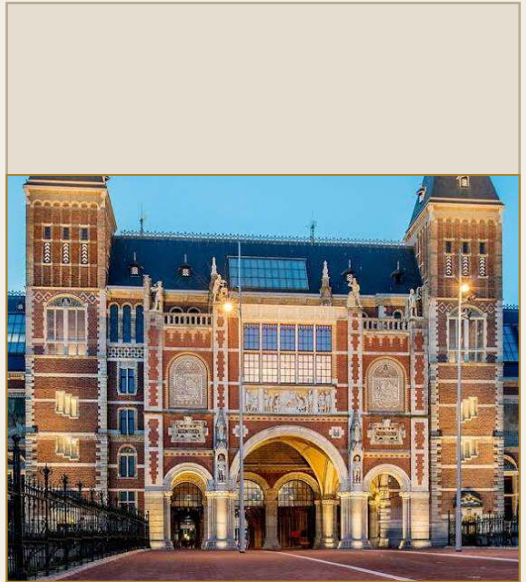
ARCHITECT(S)

Pierre Cuypers · Cruz y Ortiz (renovation, 2013)

Pierre Cuypers's cathedral-like design so offended Protestant Amsterdam in the 1880s that critics campaigned against its stained glass before it even opened. A decade-long renovation finally restored his vision in 2013, giving Rembrandt's monumental *Night Watch* a room built expressly for it — the only painting in the building to hang in the exact spot conceived for it. Visitors can now watch the canvas being restored in real time, inside a glass chamber built into the gallery itself.



The Night Watch, Rijksmuseum. Rembrandt van Rijn's 1642 militia portrait hangs in a gallery built expressly for it after the museum's 2013 renovation.



Exterior, Rijksmuseum. Pierre Cuypers's arched passage entrance, completed in 1885, cuts directly through the building on the Museumstraat.



Interior gallery, Rijksmuseum. A glass conservation chamber built into the Gallery of Honour lets visitors watch *The Night Watch* being restored in real time.

10 Van Gogh Museum

Amsterdam, Netherlands

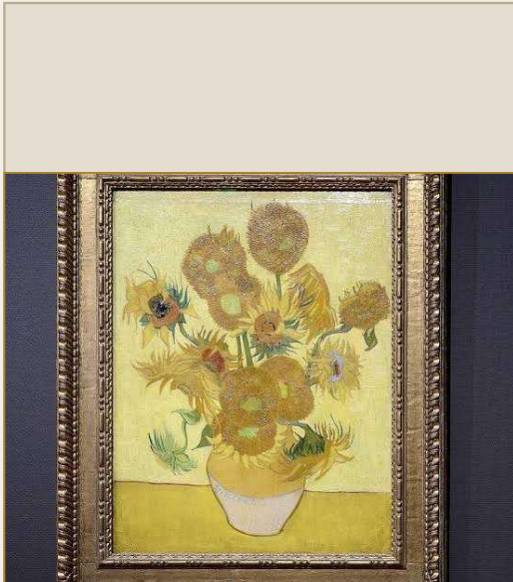
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1973

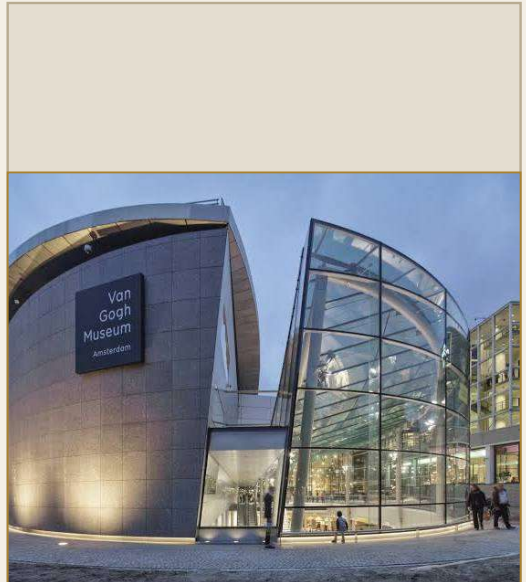
ARCHITECT(S)

Gerrit Rietveld · Kisho Kurokawa (wing, 1999)

Vincent van Gogh sold almost nothing while he lived; the museum that bears his name exists because his brother's widow, Jo van Gogh-Bonger, refused to let his work disappear after his death. She spent decades promoting the paintings her family had inherited, and in 1962 that private devotion became a public trust. Housed first in a De Stijl building by Gerrit Rietveld and later extended by Kisho Kurokawa, it now holds the largest Van Gogh collection on Earth — a posthumous fame its subject never lived to see.



Sunflowers, Van Gogh Museum. Vincent van Gogh painted this still life in Arles in 1889; it is among the most recognized of his sunflower series.



Exterior, Van Gogh Museum. Kisho Kurokawa's 1999 glass entrance wing curves beside Gerrit Rietveld's original 1973 building.



Interior gallery, Van Gogh Museum. Paintings from 1889, the year Van Gogh moved from Arles to the asylum at Saint-Rémy, hang in the museum's chronological galleries.



Entrance hall, Van Gogh Museum. Visitors gather beneath a glass staircase, with the information desks and cloakroom (Garderobe) to the right.

11 Musée d'Orsay

Paris, France

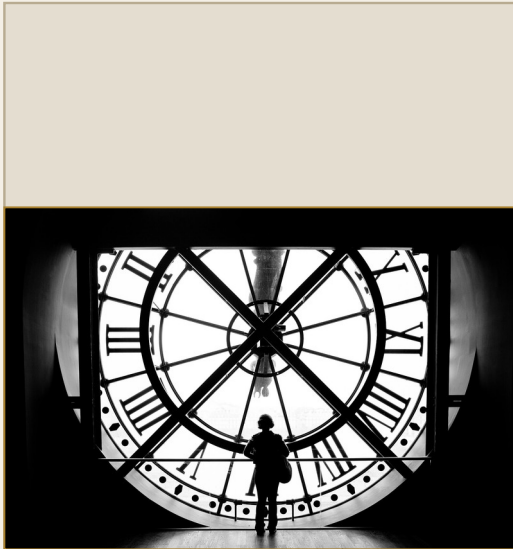
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1900 (station) · 1986 (museum)

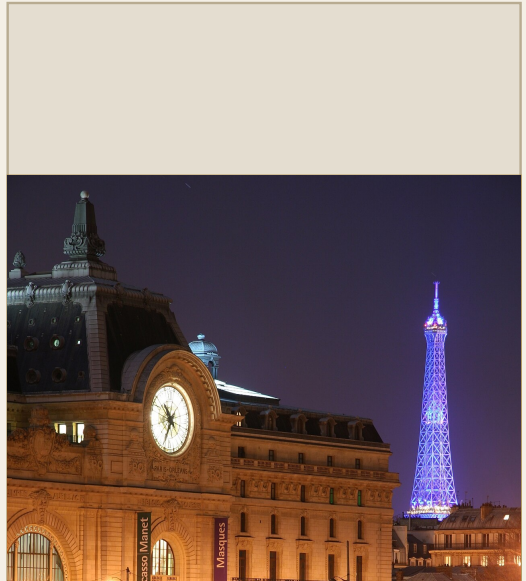
ARCHITECT(S)

Victor Laloux · Gae Aulenti (conversion, 1986)

Victor Laloux built the Gare d'Orsay for the 1900 World's Fair, an electrified marvel that within decades was too short for modern trains and faced demolition. Saved by a historic-monument listing in 1978, its cavernous train shed was reimagined by Gae Aulenti as a cathedral of Impressionism, the original station clock left glowing above galleries of Monet and Manet. Few conversions have so thoroughly repurposed one age's monument to industry into the next age's monument to art.



Station clock, Musée d'Orsay. One of the former Gare d'Orsay's great clock faces, now a window onto the city beyond.



Exterior, Musée d'Orsay. The clock and mansard roofline of the former Gare d'Orsay glow above the Seine, with the Eiffel Tower beyond.



Interior, Musée d'Orsay. Gae Aulenti's 1986 conversion preserved Victor Laloux's cast-iron train shed and its original station clock.

12 Museum of Modern Art (MoMA)

New York, USA

FOUNDED

1929

ARCHITECT(S)

Philip Goodwin & Edward Durell Stone · Yoshio Taniguchi (2004)

Three women — Abby Aldrich Rockefeller among them — founded MoMA in 1929 to champion art too radical for older museums, opening its first show days after the stock market crash. The gamble paid off: under founding director Alfred Barr, it built the collection that defined modern art for the twentieth century, from Van Gogh's swirling night sky to Warhol's soup cans. Yoshio Taniguchi's 2004 expansion nearly doubled the galleries, giving that century of radicalism room enough to breathe.



Exterior, Museum of Modern Art. The dark facade of Yoshio Taniguchi's 2004 expansion, marked by a vertical MoMA sign, rises above West 53rd Street.



Lobby, Museum of Modern Art. Taniguchi's atrium connects the ground-floor lobby and bookstore to the galleries above.

13 National Gallery of Art

Washington, D.C., USA

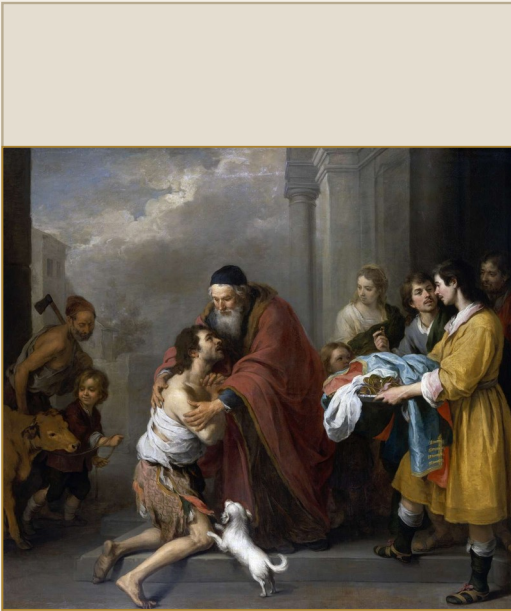
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1937

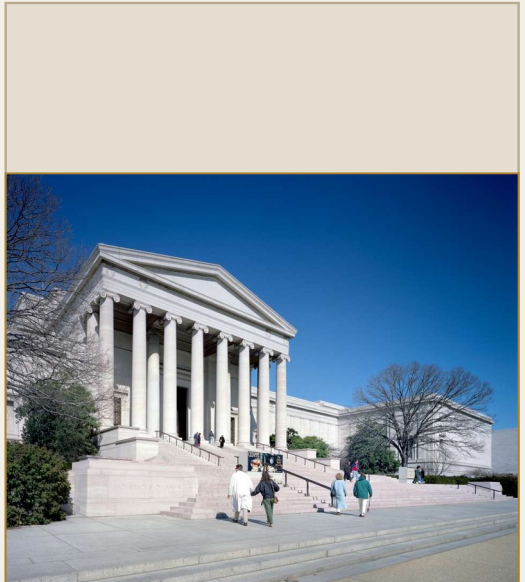
ARCHITECT(S)

John Russell Pope · I. M. Pei (East Building, 1978)

Financier Andrew Mellon gave his country an entire museum rather than just a collection, donating both his paintings and the funds to house them. He and architect John Russell Pope died within a day of each other in 1937, never seeing the marble rotunda they had designed together completed. Decades later his children commissioned I. M. Pei to add a bold modernist wing beside it — and, alone among America's great museums, the National Gallery still charges no admission at all.



The Return of the Prodigal Son, National Gallery of Art.
Bartolomé Esteban Murillo painted this canvas about 1667–70 for the Hospital de la Caridad in Seville.



Exterior, National Gallery of Art. John Russell Pope's Neoclassical West Building, completed in 1941, fronts the National Mall.



Rotunda, National Gallery of Art. A fountain and seasonal flowers fill the West Building's domed rotunda, ringed by dark green marble columns.

14 Tate Modern

London, UK

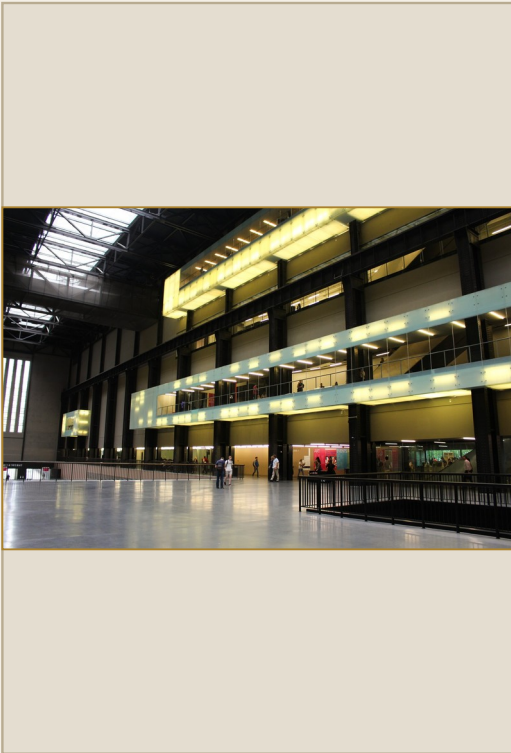
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2000

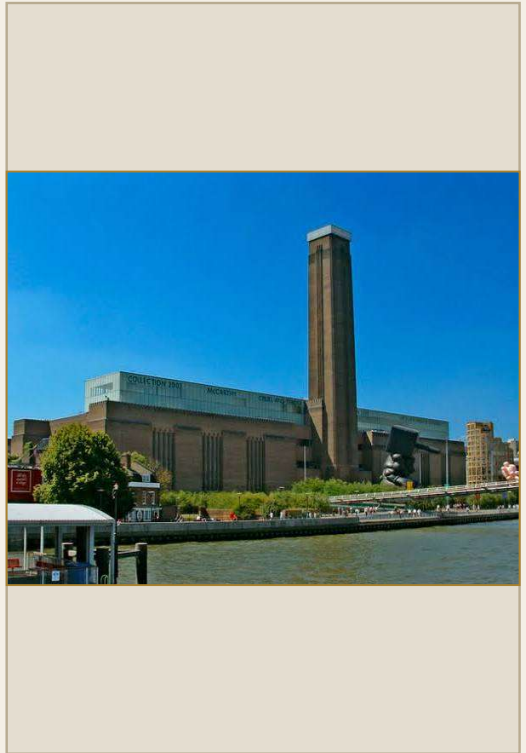
ARCHITECT(S)

Sir Giles Gilbert Scott · Herzog & de Meuron (conversion, 2000)

Bankside Power Station stopped generating electricity in 1981 and sat derelict on the Thames until Herzog & de Meuron, chosen from 148 competing firms, saw potential rather than ruin. They left Giles Gilbert Scott's brick cathedral of industry largely untouched, turning its cavernous turbine hall into the world's most-imitated space for contemporary art. Its single chimney was built, deliberately, a few meters shorter than St Paul's dome across the river — deference dressed as modesty.



Turbine Hall, Tate Modern. The former power station's vast turbine hall keeps its steel roof frame and skylights, with gallery levels glowing above the concrete floor.



Exterior, Tate Modern. Herzog & de Meuron preserved Giles Gilbert Scott's brick chimney in their 2000 conversion of Bankside Power Station.



Turbine Hall, Tate Modern. Louise Bourgeois's *Maman*, a bronze spider more than thirty feet tall, has stood in the hall since the museum's opening commission.

15 Reina Sofía Museum

Madrid, Spain

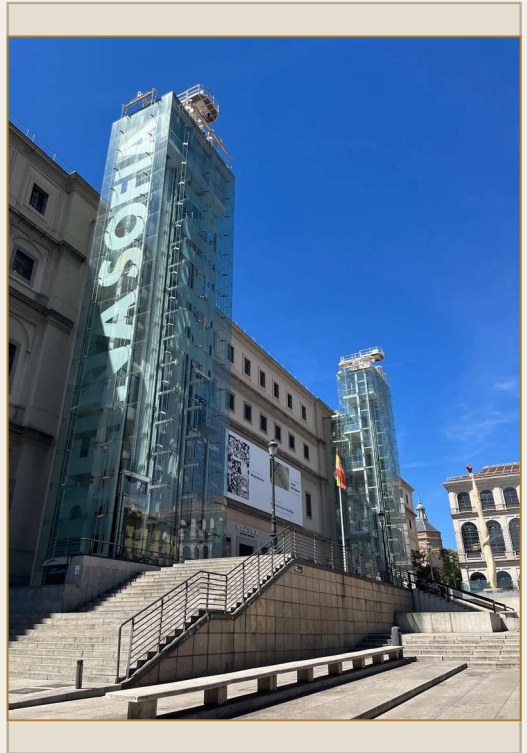
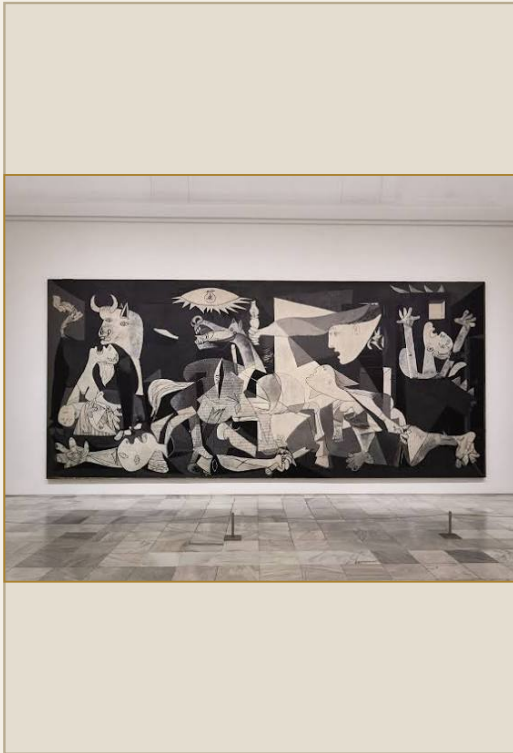
FOUNDED

1992

ARCHITECT(S)

Francesco Sabatini · Jean Nouvel (extension, 2005)

An 18th-century hospital designed under Sabatini became, two centuries later, the home of the most political painting of the modern era. Picasso painted *Guernica* in just 35 days in 1937, in protest at the bombing of a Basque town, and swore it would never hang in Spain while Franco lived. It returned in 1981, six years after the dictator's death, and now hangs — too fragile ever to travel again — within the old hospital, now framed by its glass elevator towers and Jean Nouvel's red-toned extension, added in 2005.



Exterior, Museo Reina Sofía. Sabatini's 18th-century Hospital General, begun in 1755, closed as a hospital in 1965; the glass elevator towers came with the 1980s conversion.



Nouvel extension courtyard, Museo Reina Sofía. Jean Nouvel's 2005 extension wraps this court in red-louvered walls, with Roy Lichtenstein's *Brushstroke* sculpture standing before them.

16 Galleria dell'Accademia

Florence, Italy

FOUNDED

1784

ARCHITECT(S)

Emilio De Fabris (Tribuna, 1882)

Grand Duke Pietro Leopoldo built this teaching gallery so art students could study masterworks firsthand — never imagining it would one day house the most famous statue in the world. Michelangelo's *David* waited nine years in a wooden crate after its 1873 move from the piazza, while architect Emilio De Fabris built a domed rotunda engineered purely to bathe the marble in perfect light. A modest academy gallery became, almost by accident, one of the most visited rooms on Earth.



Michelangelo's *David*, Galleria dell'Accademia. Carved between 1501 and 1504 from a single block of Carrara marble, it stood in Florence's Piazza della Signoria until it was moved indoors in 1873.



Exterior, Galleria dell'Accademia. Visitors queue along Via Ricasoli for the museum that shelters Michelangelo's *David*.



Hall of the Prisoners leading to the Tribuna, Galleria dell'Accademia. Michelangelo's unfinished *Prisoners*, carved for the tomb of Pope Julius II, line the approach to *David*, who has stood in De Fabris's Tribuna since 1873.

17 Art Institute of Chicago

Chicago, USA

FOUNDED

1879

ARCHITECT(S)

Shepley, Rutan and Coolidge · Renzo Piano (Modern Wing, 2009)

Chicago's original art academy burned to the ground in the Great Fire of 1871; from those ashes came a museum built, fittingly, to outlast disaster. Its Beaux-Arts home opened for the 1893 World's Columbian Exposition, flanked by the bronze lions that remain the city's unofficial mascots. Renzo Piano's glass-and-steel Modern Wing, connected to Millennium Park by a slender pedestrian bridge, expanded the museum by a third — proof that a museum born from a fire could still be rebuilt for the future.



Exterior, Art Institute of Chicago. The 1893 Beaux-Arts pediment and Corinthian-columned arcade, inscribed with the museum's name above the arched gallery windows.

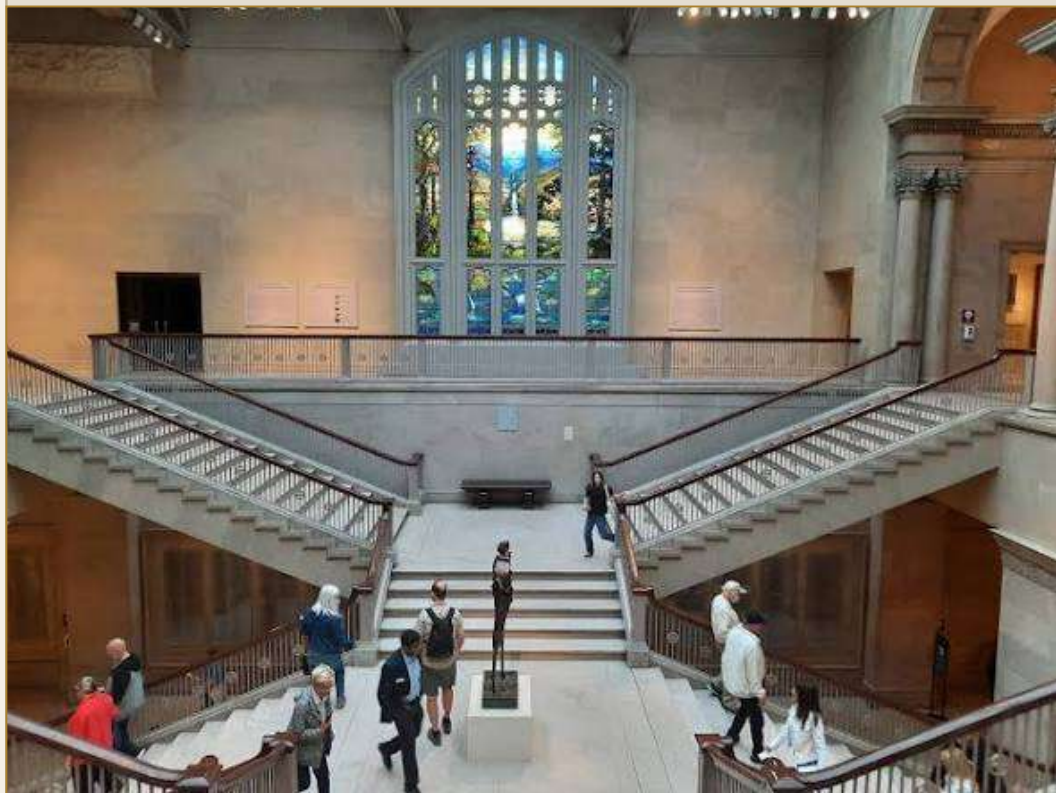


SIGNATURE ARTWORK

American Gothic

Grant Wood, 1930 · Oil on beaverboard

Grant Wood painted it in 1930, posing his dentist and his sister as the farmer and his daughter. It won a bronze medal at the Art Institute that year.



Grand Staircase, Art Institute of Chicago. Twin flights rise to a stained-glass window at the ceremonial heart of the original 1893 Beaux-Arts building.

18 Pinacoteca di Brera

Milan, Italy

FOUNDED

1809

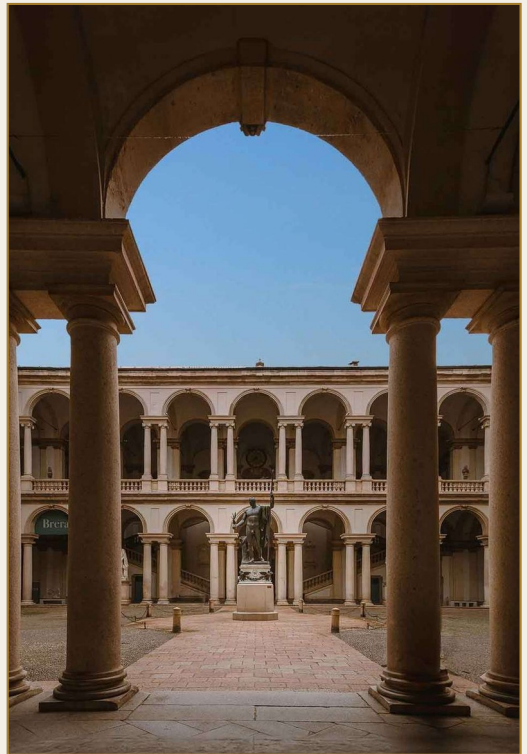
ARCHITECT(S)

Francesco Maria Ricchino

Napoleon wanted Milan to rival Paris, and so, on his own birthday in 1809, he inaugurated a gallery inside a former Jesuit college to prove it. Unlike most great collections, Brera's paintings came not from royal inheritance but from churches and convents suppressed under Napoleonic rule — an origin that still shapes its holdings of altarpieces and devotional masterworks today. Rebuilt after devastating wartime bombing, it remains a symbol of Milan's postwar cultural revival.



Signature statue, Pinacoteca di Brera. Canova's *Napoleon as Mars the Peacemaker* honors the emperor who founded the gallery in 1809.



Courtyard of the Palazzo di Brera. Ricchino's 17th-century Jesuit courtyard now frames a bronze of Napoleon; the college became a gallery in 1809.



Biblioteca Nazionale Braidense, Sala Maria Teresa. Founded by Empress Maria Theresa of Austria in 1770, the library shares the Palazzo di Brera with the gallery.

19 Museo Nacional de Antropología

Mexico City, Mexico

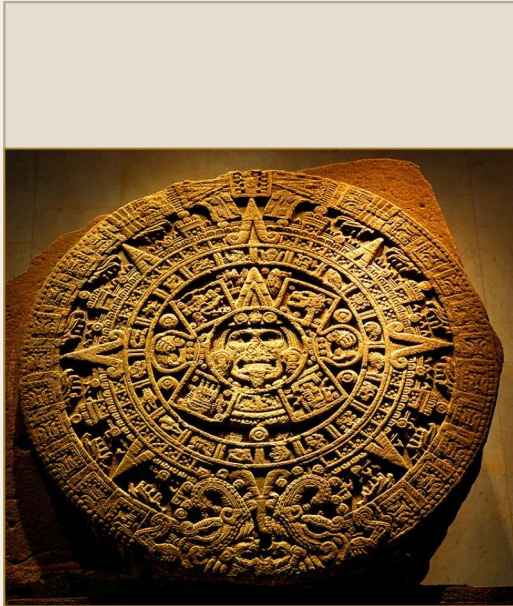
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1964

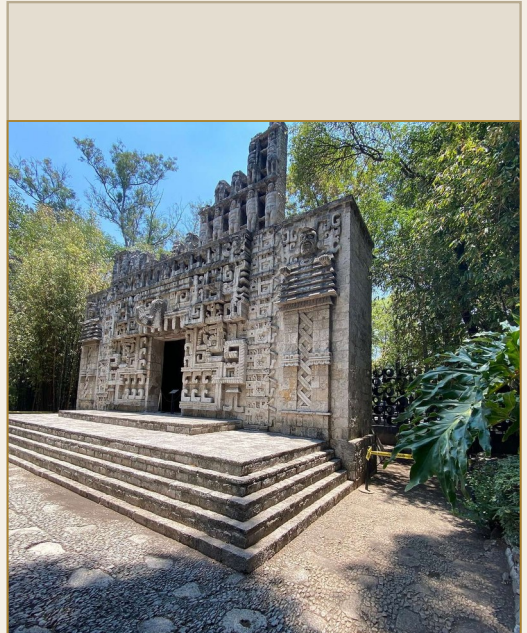
ARCHITECT(S)

Pedro Ramírez Vázquez

Built to give a nation pride in its indigenous past, Pedro Ramírez Vázquez's museum is centered on El Paraguas — a vast concrete umbrella held aloft by a single column, cascading water collected and distributed by gravity alone. On Christmas Eve 1985, thieves slipped in through an air-conditioning duct while guards celebrated the holiday and made off with more than a hundred artifacts, including the jade mask from the tomb of Pakal. The pieces resurfaced four years later, reportedly found by a thief's own mother while cleaning a closet.



The Aztec Sun Stone. This carved calendar disk was unearthed beneath Mexico City's main square in 1790; its central face is usually read as the sun god.



Reconstructed Maya temple façade in the museum's gardens. It follows the ornate Chenes-style temples of southern Mexico, letting visitors approach architecture usually seen only at distant ruins.



Interior gallery, Museo Nacional de Antropología. The Teotihuacan hall centers on the monumental water goddess Chalchiuhtlicue beside a reconstructed serpent-adorned temple façade, bringing whole monuments indoors.

20 High Museum of Art

Atlanta, USA

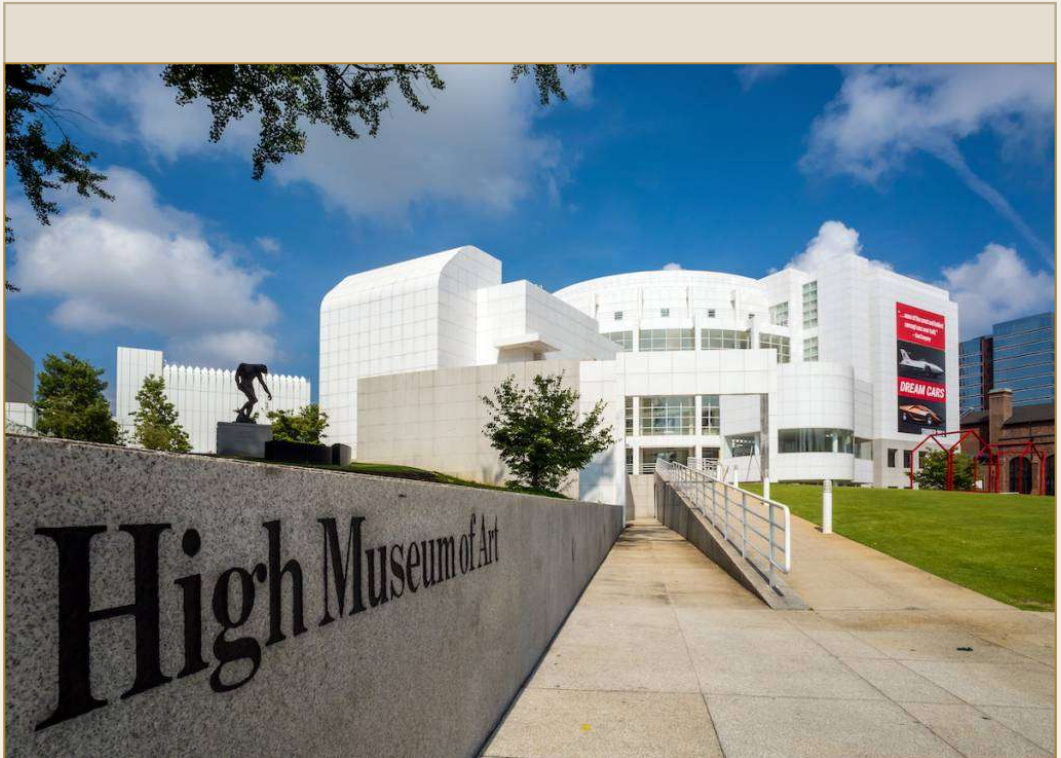
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1905 · 1983 (current building)

ARCHITECT(S)

Richard Meier · Renzo Piano (2005)

In 1905 a handful of Atlanta women founded the Atlanta Art Association with little more than a conviction that their city deserved a museum of its own. That conviction found a permanent home in 1926, when Mrs. Joseph M. High donated the family's Peachtree Street residence, lending the museum both a building and, eventually, its name. The luminous white galleries visitors know today opened in 1983, a curving design by Richard Meier built around a four-story atrium inspired by the Guggenheim. Renzo Piano's 2005 expansion more than doubled its footprint, knitting new pavilions into what the architect called a 'village for the arts.' For our family the High holds a more personal chapter still: its art school gave Gabriela her first lessons in painting, under a teacher she has never forgotten.



Exterior view of the High Museum of Art. Richard Meier's 1983 white porcelain-enamel building rises above Peachtree Street.



Interior gallery. Three of Gabriela's original oil paintings shown in the High Museum, where her first lessons in painting began.

A TRIBUTE TO HER TEACHER

the High Museum's art school, and Kristopher B. Meadows — written by Gabriela

It was at the suggestion of my beloved husband, Donald — always full of clever ideas — that he first opened the door for me into the world of art. One day I enrolled at the High Museum, hoping to awaken something in myself that I never knew I had — an aptitude that would shape the rest of my life.

My teacher, Kristopher B. Meadows, taught me the first foundations of oil painting, and in doing so awakened in me a deep passion for it. Being surrounded in class by others who shared the same dream made every moment feel real — as if I were already an artist in the making.

Later, I came to live in Cali, Colombia, South America, where fortune brought me to a painting teacher beyond description. His patience, and the confidence he placed in me, freed me to paint without fear and to pour my true feelings onto the canvas. His name is Alfredo Vives, of Peruvian origin. From him I learned that painting would be my life's purpose — and that one day, perhaps, I might come close to his talent.

To paint is to dream. To put your feelings into it is something only an artist truly lives.

I share these wonderful experiences with you.

— Gabriela